

Week 7 — Talking to Real People

Goal: Have real conversations with at least **two people** who do the work — an engineer, a technician, an apprentice, a community college engineering instructor, anyone actually on the path. This is the single highest-value week and the one that most requires leaving your comfort zone. That's not a side effect; it's the point. Interviews, first days, and asking for raises all live outside the comfort zone too, and this is the practice version where nothing bad can happen.

Part 1: Get the conversations

Finding people (in rough order of ease): 1. **Family network first.** Parents' friends, friends' parents, neighbors, anyone at church/gym/etc. who works in manufacturing, utilities, construction trades, or engineering. One ask — “do you know anyone who works as an engineer or technician I could talk to for 20 minutes?” — usually produces someone. 2. **Community college.** Email an engineering/engineering-tech instructor: you're deciding between programs and would love 15 minutes. Instructors answer these emails; recruiting interested students is their job. 3. **LinkedIn.** Find technicians/engineers at your Week 3 companies. Short message: who you are, one specific thing about their company from your research, and a request for 15–20 minutes of advice. Send 8–10 to get 2 yeses — low reply rates are normal and not about you. 4. **Walk in.** Small machine shops and repair shops are often genuinely happy to give a curious 18-year-old ten minutes and a tour. Go at a non-busy hour, be brief, be polite.

The magic words: people flinch at “can I interview you” but say yes to “*I'm trying to figure out if this is the right path for me — could I ask you a few questions about how you got started?*” You are asking for advice, not a job. People love giving advice.

Prepare 6–8 questions. Good ones:

- How did you get your start? What would you do differently at 18?
- What does a normal day actually look like?
- What separates the new hires who move up from the ones who don't?
- Does your company help pay for school? How does that work in practice — do people really use it?
- What should I learn *right now* to be useful on day one?
- Does your company take **interns or co-op students**? Who runs that program?
- Your held-over question from Week 1 — the one the internet couldn't answer
- End with: “*Is there anyone else you think I should talk to?*” (This is how 2 interviews become 4.)

Afterward: send a thank-you text/email within 24 hours. Every time. Write notes immediately — you'll forget the good stuff within a day.

Part 2: Essay (600–900 words)

Prompt: *“What the people doing this job told me.”*

Requirements:

- What did each person say that you couldn’t have gotten from the internet?
- What surprised you? What contradicted your Weeks 1–5 research? (When a person and a website disagree, that’s the most interesting data you have — dig into why.)
- Did anything change your plan? Even “no, and here’s why I’m more sure now” counts — but defend it.
- Be honest about the hardest part: reaching out. What did the discomfort feel like before vs. after? Was the anticipation worse than the conversation? (It almost always is. Notice that — it’s the most transferable finding of the whole program.)

Done when

- ☐ 2+ real conversations completed, notes written up
- ☐ Thank-you messages sent
- ☐ Essay written
- ☐ Walkthrough conversation done